



No Logo? No Way. Branding in the Non-Profit Sector.

Helen Stride & Stephen Lee

To cite this article: Helen Stride & Stephen Lee (2007) No Logo? No Way. Branding in the Non-Profit Sector., Journal of Marketing Management, 23:1-2, 107-122, DOI: [10.1362/026725707X178585](https://doi.org/10.1362/026725707X178585)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1362/026725707X178585>



Published online: 01 Feb 2010.



Submit your article to this journal [↗](#)



Article views: 4378



View related articles [↗](#)



Citing articles: 9 View citing articles [↗](#)

No Logo? No Way. Branding in the Non-Profit Sector.

Helen Stride, *Henley Management College, UK**

Stephen Lee, *Henley Management College, UK*

Abstract Ten thousand new organisations are joining the charity sector each year (Hankinson 2000). One of the ways in which charities are responding to this increased competition is to adopt commercial branding techniques (Tapp 1996; Ritchie, Swami et al. 1998). It has been suggested that brand orientation can help to raise awareness amongst target audiences (Hankinson 2000), build loyalty within donor and supporter groups (Ritchie, Swami et al. 1998) and facilitate donor choice (Hankinson 2000). This paper investigates what is understood by the term brand, what constitutes a brand in the charity environment and what organisational objectives a brand strategy seeks to achieve. It also explores the role played by values in developing charity brands. The research is primarily exploratory in nature, drawing on existing branding theory. The findings of the research are reviewed within the context of for-profit and not-for-profit branding literature. Recommendations for further research are also made.

Keywords Branding, Non-profit branding, Brand values

INTRODUCTION

The non-profit sector in England and Wales is growing at a rate of ten thousand new organisations each year (Hankinson 2000). One of the ways in which non-profits are responding to this increase in competition is by adopting branding techniques developed in the corporate context. Whilst it is argued by some that brand orientation helps voluntary organisations develop trust across key stakeholder communities (Tapp 1996; Ritchie, Swami et al. 1998), strengthen awareness amongst

*Correspondence details and biographies for the authors are located at the end of the article, p. 122.

target audiences (Hankinson 2000) and build charity loyalty within donor and supporter groups (Ritchie, Swami et al. 1998), other academics and practitioners have expressed concern that the unquestioned adoption of techniques developed in the for-profit context has contributed to the charity sector becoming over-commercialised (Sternberg 1998; Salamon 1999).

Sternberg (1998) argues that the commercialisation of the sector may have resulted in charities losing something of their unique nature, having failed to develop their own identity as values based organisations. It is claimed that values are a charity's *raison d'être*, giving legitimacy to its very existence (Hudson 1995) and as such have a non-negotiable quality (Stride 2003).

Given the fundamental importance of values in non-profit activity as expressed in this debate, it is surprising that there is little evidence that the values construct in branding, so important now in the development of the theoretical understanding of the brand in the commercial context, has hardly been considered in the context of non-profit branding. Further, whilst research has shown that branding can enhance a wide range of charity activities, there continues to be little understanding of the conceptualisation of values within non-profit brands, or the importance of values in the practical application and the management of those brands.

To investigate these issues in greater detail, exploratory research was conducted with senior executives in major UK charities and specialist non-profit communications consultants in an attempt to clarify what is understood by the term branding in the non-profit sector. Specifically, the research aimed to investigate the practical application of branding and the role that values play in this process.

BRANDING IN THE FOR-PROFIT CONTEXT

In response to the growing importance of branding, in 1960 the American Marketing Association (AMA) defined brand as: 'a name, term, sign, symbol, or design, or a combination of them, intended to identify the goods or services of one seller or group of sellers and to differentiate them from those of competitors'.

Whilst differentiation remains the key objective of branding (Kapferer 1992), the focus of branding has shifted from the tangible aspects such as name and logo to intangible elements such as brand personality and emotional benefits (Aaker 1996; Keller 1998). With advances in technology that made it possible for companies to replicate high quality products of their competitors it was no longer sufficient just to promote a product, it had to be enhanced in some way (Kotler 1997). Brands therefore acquired an emotional dimension that reflected buyers' moods, personalities and the messages they wish to convey to others (de Chernatony and Dall'Olmio Riley 1998).

De Chernatony and Dall'Olmio Riley (1998) argue that values lie at the heart of the branding concept and define it as "a complex multidimensional construct whereby managers augment products and services with values and this facilitates the process by which consumers confidently recognise and appreciate these values" (p427).

Imbued with its own unique qualities and characteristics, a brand can provide emotional and self-expressive benefits to the consumer. An understanding of the complex values dimension operating within the brand relationship provides the consumer with an opportunity to express symbolically an actual self (Belk 1988), or an ideal self (Malhotra 1988). Brand image, or how the consumer perceives the brand, plays a central role in the Customer Based Brand Equity model (Keller 1998) where it is claimed that 'the power of a brand lies in what resides in the minds of

customers' (p59). Boulding (1956) was one of the early writers to understand the power of image development, recognising that people do not respond to objective reality but to their perception of reality.

Within this more sophisticated conceptualisation of the brand, it is the knowledge that consumers' have about a brand that provides them with brand value. Brand Knowledge consists of brand awareness and brand image, the latter being formed from the associations made by the consumer with the brand. It is these associations that in turn provide emotional, self-expressive and functional benefits to the recipient (Aaker 1996).

Although the term brand is still often used interchangeably with product, recent research and practitioner interest increasingly focuses brand and brand management away from product level brands to brands built around company values. In this scenario there must be alignment between the values that the brand espouses and the enactment of the organisation's values experienced by the consumer via staff behaviour. To ensure strong brand performance therefore, staff will have to understand the brand's vision and values and be totally committed to their delivery (De Chernatony 1999).

BRANDING IN THE NOT-FOR-PROFIT CONTEXT

At a superficial level the branding concept now appears well advanced within the larger non-profit community. Major arts and performance companies (La Scala Opera, the Royal Shakespeare Company etc.) use strong brand awareness to attract and retain both world class performers and premium paying audiences - maintaining market leadership in the process. Museums and universities (Smithsonian, Harvard, Oxford and Cambridge etc.) achieve global reach and reputation in both research and teaching credibility, in part at least, through effective brand management; whilst international NGO brands (i.e. WWF International, Oxfam, Habitat for Humanity) are now valued in terms of the trust that the brand has the capacity to generate and in their own commercial worth. Non-profit brands are increasingly recognised as being amongst the strongest brands in the world (Quelch et al. 2004).

Not only is the significance of non-profit brands gaining greater attention but the sentiment that branding is as appropriate a marketing technique for non-profit organisations as it is for 'selling shampoo' (Wray 1994) is shared by an increasing community of academics and practitioners (Tapp 1996; Ritchie, Swami et al. 1998; Hankinson 2000). Facing continuing pressure to assure revenues - the contention behind much of the literature is that as the non-profit environment becomes increasingly over-crowded, branding is needed to build trust and help facilitate donor choice (Hankinson 2000).

However, whilst non-profit organisations recognise the importance of top-of-mind awareness for attracting limited human and financial resources (Ritchie et al. 1998), it has been argued that the way in which they currently raise their profiles may not be always effective at fully explaining the purpose of the organisation and what the non-profit organisation actually does (Hankinson 2000).

Effective brand management in the non-profit context is more complex than simply satisfying donor needs. To be truly effective, non-profit brands need to address a number of additional organisational objectives. The most widely cited include lobbying (Hankinson 2000), education and the communication of the cause itself (Tapp 1996) and image and reputation management (Polonsky and Macdonald 2000).

ORGANISATIONAL VALUES IN THE NOT-FOR-PROFIT SECTOR

Whilst trust may be considered to be of particular importance in the non-profit sector, it is the sector's dependence upon values (as opposed to profit) in general that differentiates it from the corporate sector: values are a charity's basic *raison d'être*, giving legitimacy to its very existence (Hudson 1995; Aiken 2001).

Without these values some charities either would not exist, or should not exist (Batsleer, Cornforth et al. 1991). Sargeant and Lee (2004) support this view by claiming that the consideration of values lie at the heart of every charity. Although difficult to identify (Becker and Conner 1986), it is argued that the maintenance and development of these values is important both to the sector and to the wider society (Aiken 2001).

The word charity, a central construct in non-profit legitimisation, has Latin origins; *caritas* means beneficence to those in need and, like philanthropy, it means love of people (Bruce 1998). This sense of wanting to help other people without seeking personal benefit (Hudson 1995) is encapsulated in the legislation that governs charitable activity wherever civil society flourishes. Although the aim of the non-profit sector is to bring about positive change in individuals and society, the ultimate test (both in achieving mission and in the manner in which the mission is achieved) is conceptualised through the attainment of purposive, values laden, 'right action' (Drucker 2001).

Further support of the centrality of this values-based approach is demonstrated by organisational behaviour – non-profit organisations often advocate a participative way of working. Indeed, Hudson (1995) argues that a non-profit's values must be cherished even where it may be difficult to develop a single, coherent, philosophical position across the entire organisation (Bruce 1998).

For an organisation to work towards a specific charitable purpose that is of benefit to society, it must have a value system that both underpins and indeed drives the charity's operations. This implies that the values are not optional or negotiable but are integral to the organisation itself (Stride 2003). This contrasts with the more flexible nature of values in the commercial context, the objective of which is to ensure survival in an external environment (Schein 1985).

In the non-profit branding context, it is not the non-profit sector's dependence upon values *per se* that distinguishes it from the corporate sector, but rather the non-negotiability of values in the non-profit context (Stride 2003).

THE VALUES DIMENSION IN NON-PROFIT BRANDING

Despite the recognition of the central importance of organisational values in understanding the distinctive nature of non-profit organisations, the non-profit branding literature has largely neglected detailed discussion of the impact of values in the articulation and management of non-profit brands.

Whilst extant research indicates that many non-profit organisations are embracing the concept of branding at a tangible level with the adoption of a professionally designed logo (Tapp 1996), there is less evidence of the successful application of a brand's intangible dimensions.

Typically, Naddaff (2004) notes that,

"a solid brand image and brand experience strengthen an organization both internally, from a volunteer and donor perspective, and externally. Good branding should translate into good design, because, often, it's the organization's logo, brochure or web site that are noticed and remembered." (Naddaff 2004)

He points out that whilst concentration upon mission and vision achievement and core values is crucial to successful branding, so to remains the ability to differentiate through image in a competitive and increasingly cluttered marketplace. This, both he and the majority of non-profit branding commentators would agree, is first achieved through effective logo, tagline and identity design (Ind and Bell 1999, Naddaf 2004,).

If non-profits have become increasingly adept in understanding and managing the tangible elements of their brands – logo, design, consistency in corporate architecture etc. - they have done so at the risk of identifying all the significant elements of their brand simply within a mechanistic, design-led focus upon their corporate identity.

By contrast, in studies where values are inculcated into the equation, brand personalities in the non-profit sector have been portrayed as ill-defined and confused, resulting in different stakeholders perceiving brands in different ways (Hankinson 2000). Indeed, the only previous attempt to operationalise brand values in the non-profit context in an explicit sense has met with inconclusive results (Sargeant et al. 2005).

Whilst there is growing evidence that branding techniques are being embraced by the non-profit sector, it would appear that branding is being used in a descriptive and tactical way with an absence of strategic application. Also, there is little if any evidence that the values construct in branding (which is of increasing importance in the commercial theoretical context), is being fully utilised in the non-profit environment (Sargeant et al. 2005).

Despite the importance of values in the non-profit sector, it is ironic that there is a shortage of research in the non-profit literature defining or explaining the role of organisational values in the non-profit branding context. Given the highly distinctive and important role that organisational values play in the definition and understanding of non-profit organisations, it would appear counter intuitive to suggest that the values dimension in non-profit branding would not carry some significance.

Conversely, neglect of the analysis of the values dimension within non-profit brands both in extant research and in practitioner understanding might lead to an inappropriate perception of the worth and significance of these brands by academics, brand managers and by the publics that interact with them. There is some support for this proposition. Participation, the propensity toward cultural inclusiveness and a mutual respect for individual and organisational values, have all been found to be significant factors in the development of more effective branding strategies within the non-profit context. (Ind and Bell 2000)

METHODOLOGY

In seeking to develop a greater understanding of the conceptualisation of non-profit brands and their values dimensions, exploratory analysis utilising a qualitative methodology was adopted. More specifically in-depth, semi-structured interviews with key informants (Marshall and Rossman 1999) were conducted across a sample of senior, non-profit directors and consultants. This methodology provides a framework

for data collection when there is a basis for further developing underlying theory (Cowles, Kiecker and Little 2002).

The interviews were conducted with eight directors from major non-profit fundraising organisations with recognised brands and three specialist non-profit communications consultants. The charities represented a cross section of charitable causes including; conservation, the environment, the elderly, children (in the UK and internationally) and development. Representatives from a single cause charity and a fundraising and educational organisation were also interviewed.

The key informants interviewed, all of whom had extensive experience of brand development in the non-profit context, were selected on the basis of the insights that they are able to provide in terms of the research (George and Reve 1982). Each interview was semi-structured (see appendix 1) and lasted between one and one and a half hours. Whilst the interview schedule demonstrates that there was a 'clear list issues to be addressed' (Denscombe 2003), the process was sufficiently flexible to allow the interviewees to frame responses in a way that most accurately reflected their own experience (Marshall and Rossman 1999). The interviews were recorded and were then transcribed and carefully re-read to prepare the ground for analysis (Dey 1993 p83) recognising that familiarity with data helps to identify patterns, inconsistencies and contradictions (Hammersley and Atkinson 1995).

The questions focused on a number of key issues. Participants were first asked what terminology was used when discussing the organisational image or identity. They were then asked what constituted the charity's brand and what the objectives were in developing a brand. Questions then focused on trying to understand the antecedents and consequences of branding.

To reduce the data and assist with data management, a coding system was adopted. The coded data was initially grouped according to each of the research questions being addressed. Within each of the categories, it was possible to identify three or four themes that provided the framework for data analysis. In this context coding conforms to Miles and Huberman's (1994) definition whereby a code is attached to a segment of text that be a group of words, a phrase, sentence or paragraph. Coding the text in this way means that the text can be organised by segments and then retrieved. The qualitative data analysis software, Atlas.ti, was used to code the data and assist with subsequent analysis.

RESEARCH FINDINGS

Four key themes emerged from the data analysis: the manner in which the brand is understood or conceptualised internally; the processes by which brand development takes place, and in particular the internal challenges that must be overcome; issues surrounding the ongoing management of the brand and the role played in the branding process by organisational values. Before looking at each of these factors in turn, the paper will first explore the findings that relate specifically to the use of and attitudes towards the term 'brand' in the not-for-profit environment

Brand Terminology

Most interviewees mentioned that there was often initial resistance to the term brand, even at a senior level. A senior communications director reported that the term brand had been regarded as a '*dirty word*' that would "*commercialise and undermine the*

integrity of the mission”.

Others associated the term with products and therefore felt that it would not do justice to the work of the organisation. To address initial resistance, some of the organisations researched adopted alternative terminology in an attempt to overcome the negative conception of brand and brand management held in the mind of key audiences. Alternative terms of persona, identity and public image were utilised alongside brand as a means to desensitise stakeholder response to the onset of brand development.

A number of respondents felt that staff were eventually persuaded that branding was in the interest of the organisation. One interviewee, the director of a development charity, had told staff that they *“had to engage with this stuff”*, suggesting that some may have needed more persuading than others.

Each of the senior non-profit consultants interviewed reflected a view commonly held across the data sample that *“they [the charities] are using every terminology under the sun”*, where branding is in some instances being used to describe a logo etc, whilst on other occasions it is seen to relate to vision, mission and values.

There appears then to be little agreed consensus as to precisely what shared branding terminology actually means, in practice, in the non-profit branding context. Further, in a significant number of responses, branding terminology itself appears to deliver negative rather than positive associations across key recipient stakeholder groups.

Understanding the Branding Concept

From the analysis of data relating to brand conceptualisation, two distinct clusters of data emerged. One relates to how branding is conceptualised by the executives interviewed and the other is concerned with the reasons for embarking upon a branding process.

Conceptualisation

So what is understood by the term brand in the charity arena? Brand was most frequently referred to in tangible terms, as a method for developing the organisation’s visual identity in a consistent manner. The Head of Marketing from a leading children’s charity gave a typical response when he explained, *“brand gets narrowed down to what’s the logo, what’s the strap-line”*. Another from a development charity indicated that everyone agreed that we *“had to look the same”*.

Some of the consultants interviewed articulated how the more abstract conceptualisations of brand could manifest in tangible aspects of the brand architecture such as in the strap-line. A managing director felt that the essence of the charity brand is the charity’s cause and that this is often encapsulated in slogans such as *“helping people help themselves”* and *“turning science into hope”*.

Whilst a minority of the charity executives interviewed also alluded to the more intangible aspects of brand, with one communications director saying that brand manifested *“in all of the experiences that stakeholders had with an organisation”* and another (an executive from a conservation charity) claiming that *“brands...carry so much - just those words, those names and those logos”*, there was little evidence from the interviews that the emotional dimensions of brand are being either carefully managed or fully utilised.

These inconsistencies may be due in part to the apparent lack of consensus regarding the role of a brand. On the one hand brand is seen as tool to support

the fundraising operation, on the other it is viewed from a holistic perspective, as illustrated by one communications director who said that he would *'approach brand as being what [the] values are of the organisation, the set of things you stand for and seek to do'*.

Why Do Non-profits Construct Brands

The findings from this research suggest that branding is still an emergent concept in the charity context. Whilst respondents talked enthusiastically about branding, it was rarely discussed in terms of it being an important strategic tool in its own right. Most interviewees saw branding essentially as a problem solver. One of the key issues for which branding was considered to be a remedy was low public awareness. Another frequently mentioned motivation for adopting a branding approach was to create a coherent and consistent communication programme.

As one director of communications noted, in recalling a conversation with a recently appointed chief executive who asked for her opinion on strategic issues that needed addressing, *"I said brand identity because there were 280 people going out of this building defining it differently"*. The tentative relationship that the non-profit sector seems to have with branding was further illustrated by a marketing director, who said *"once we realised that actually what we had on our hands was a brand we started to think about it more in those terms"*.

Brand Development

In response to questions that attempted to elicit information concerning the antecedents and consequences of branding, participants were inclined to discuss brand implementation or how brands were developed and managed. Within the first of these areas, brand development, issues emerged relating to levels of participation, the need to communicate multiple messages to multiple audiences and tension between fundraising and departments such as campaigning and service provision.

Levels of Participation in Brand Development

A number of interviewees mentioned the importance of adopting a participative approach to brand development. One talked of defining the brand together across the whole organisation, while another referred to having used a consultative process that involved a range of different stakeholder groups. For the majority of interviewees, a participatory approach was seen as a prerequisite to effective decision making in the non-profit context. As one indicative response from a deputy director from a children's charity indicates, a number of consultants had been rejected during their branding process because they *"simply did not understand staff involvement"*.

Multiple Messages to Multiple Audiences

The diversity of the work of many of the charities interviewed was seen as one of the greatest challenges to developing a consistent brand. Many of the charities existed not only to serve the beneficiaries for which the cause was originally created directly, but were also engaged in a wide range of additional, supportive activities involving education, campaigning and advocacy activity.

The challenge of managing brand communications across such a diverse range of activities was effectively summarised by a communications director, *"we have a campaigning arm, a fundraising and a trading arm all of which have different takes*

on the brand”.

Another senior director from a development charity highlighted how the situation could be further complicated by the size and reach of a large international NGO operating in a global environment whilst needing to remain relevant, attentive and responsive to a diverse range of stakeholder groups both at home and abroad, *“we have change objectives at a global, regional and project level...with democratic rights, gender and other forms of equity ...that cut across all three of them”*.

The participative nature of the working style of the majority of organisations analysed meant that for each different area of work that they engaged in there was often a different stakeholder group taking a primary interest. In response, one interviewee stressed that their charity not only communicated the brand in different ways to different stakeholder groups, but that in some cases their charity had different relationships with different groups altogether.

Interestingly the majority of the external consultants interviewed expressed the view that the only way to address the issue of communicating multiple messages to multiple audiences in the non-profit context was to develop, as described by one managing director, an *‘umbrella message’*. Another non-profit consultant argued that *‘it’s a fallacy that you can’t have universal messages for an entire organisation.’*

Although interviewees reported the use of multiple channels to communicate their brand to different audiences advertising was considered to be the most effective way to co-ordinate a range of communication messages across different audiences. Of all the channels utilised, not surprisingly for these larger non-profit organisations, television was considered to provide greatest visibility and to be the most effective way to raise awareness. As one consultant put it *‘If you have got the press behind you and it’s on everybody’s lips, you’ve got people’*.

However, for those who invested in television advertising there was a perceived negative impact on the brand from the audiences they were targeting. One head of marketing commented, *“there are people who argue that charities shouldn’t be spending money just on advertising, therefore, [we] need to justify [its] effectiveness”*.

Fundraising Vs Other Areas

Respondents indicate that well established (or entrenched) bureaucratic positioning within and across interdepartmental factions within non-profit organisations can lead to real friction and internal conflict both in the general management of the organisation, and in the particular ability (or otherwise) to manage its brand in a coherent and cohesive manner. This would appear to be particularly marked with regard to the way fundraising communications and branding are regarded elsewhere in the organisation.

A senior executive from a conservation charity described the tension caused by how the brand was utilised by fundraising teams compared to teams engaged in campaigning or service delivery as *“trying to hold two wild horses running in the opposite direction”* where one team was interested in *“get[ing] the cash in”* whilst the other wanted to adopt a more *holistic approach* to communication. In another situation this tension manifested itself between portraying beneficiaries positively in advocacy campaigns whilst illustrating the negative side of their condition when fundraising.

One non-profit consultant described how some within the non-profit organisation would consequently view fundraising as at best a *‘necessary evil’* tolerated by the need to ensure revenues, whilst at worst a direct negative challenge to the communications

messages being developed and implemented elsewhere within the organisation.

The net result of this expressed lack of synergy around agreed common purpose and mutual respect for divergent communications tactics to meet differing needs across differing stakeholder groups in complex non-profit organisations, represents a particular challenge to non-profit brand managers seeking to eradicate inconsistency in brand application across the organisation and at the same time ensuring a coherent understanding of what the brand stands for universally

Brand Management

It is interesting to note that in responding to the brand management challenges identified above, the principle mechanisms introduced by charities for coordinating the branding process cited in this research appear to focus predominantly on managing the visual identity.

A number of participant organisations had introduced a brand handbook to provide information on such matters as the brand name, the logo, photography, copy style and typeface. On some, limited occasions a summary of brand values was also included. Attitudes towards the enforcement of such guidelines varied between interviewees. Whilst some talked about the need to strike a balance between consistency and flexibility, with a senior executive from a children's charity describing it as "*horses for courses*", others felt that their existing identity manual was not prescriptive enough. Rather than enforce their guidelines, one organisation had appointed a "*brand champion*" as a way of ensuring that staff felt empowered in the brand communication process.

The type of management controls that may be needed to ensure brand consistency (Keller 1998) seemed to challenge either implicitly or explicitly the underlying value systems of some of non-profit organisations interviewed. One executive talked openly about the need to balance consistency and flexibility, recognising that a rigid system would require enforcement that would undermine their belief in empowerment. Another talked about staff not wanting to "*follow the corporate line all the way to the letter*". For a single cause organisation however, for whom empowerment was also important, the guidelines in place apparently "*gave people too much freedom*".

One non-profit consultant drew a distinction between a brand's visual identity, which could be controlled, or '*policed*' and the deeper, underlying values of the brand for which greater ownership or buy-in from stakeholders was required. In the latter case the adoption of shared belief through participation was viewed as a more effective management process than control imposed simply by authority.

The Role Played by Values in the Branding Process

The findings of the research confirm that values are thought by senior communications executives to be integral to the work of charitable organisations (Handy 1990). Values were considered to be important because charities are in the business of "*changing minds and behaviour*", argued one marketing director.

The importance of values manifesting in organisational behaviour was expressed by a number of executives. For example, one interviewee stressed that cooperation was reflected in their management style, treating each other "*with respect and integrity*". Several executives mentioned the commitment of staff to organisational values. One marketing director said "*we are very passionate about what we do*", whilst another said, "*when I came here I was bowled over by the depth of commitment of the staff*".

The importance of shared organisational values extended beyond the staff to include other stakeholder groups. One interviewee talked about the need to reflect back to stakeholders their values and their perception of organisational values.

For the majority of respondents the issue of values was inextricably linked to trust. Trust was considered to be of such fundamental importance that every interviewee mentioned it. It was referred to on more than one occasion as a 'hygiene factor', a pre-requisite to any legitimate non-profit activity. One director made the link between trust and supporters having confidence in the work of an organisation, particularly in relation to how donated money was spent. Trust was also considered to be essential for an organisation's ongoing credibility. As one senior executive from a development charity put it, "*if you are not honest, you're not there*". Another from a conservation charity said that without trust '*you're in pretty bad shape*'.

The types of values that underpinned the work of the organisations involved in the research, according to the executives interviewed were predominately humanitarian in nature. The values that were most regularly mentioned alongside trust and integrity were empowering, inclusive, consultative, inspirational and respectful. Related working practices that were considered to be of fundamental importance were accountability and transparency. As one marketing director noted in making the connection between transparency and trust, "*we are accountable for every single penny that we spend because we can't risk losing [that] trust by doing something stupid*".

CONCLUSIONS

Brand Conceptualisation

The non-profit branding literature suggests that branding is one of the ways in which charities have responded to increased competition (Hankinson 2000). In the commercial context differentiation from competitors is indeed the driving force behind branding (Kapferer 1992), lying at the very heart of branding conceptualisation. It is interesting to note therefore that whilst the consultants interviewed in this research did indeed conceptualise branding in terms of positioning and competition, there was little if any suggestion from that charity executives that charity branding is viewed in these terms.

This apparent lack of external perspective on the part of senior non-profit communications staff may help to explain why those charities interviewed gave the development of a coherent communications programme as one of the main reasons for brand development. Whilst awareness - raising was also mentioned as a desired outcome, it was rarely referred to in terms of the needs of the 'supporter', or external audience, as recommended in the for-profit literature.

The most frequent way in which brand was conceptualised by the executives interviewed was as visual identity which incorporated tangible dimensions of the brand such as logo, name and design style. Whilst one consultant argued that charities have always had personalities, there is little to suggest that the intangible dimensions of branding are being explored in any systematic way.

Brand Development

In the for-profit context, brand development is primarily the responsibility of either a brand manager (Low and Fullerton 1994) or increasingly the Chief Executive (Berthon,

Hulbert et al. 1999). The research presented suggests that brand development in the charity sector however is often conducted in a consultative manner, involving both staff and other stakeholder groups. This is a view supported in the non-profit branding literature. In developing Barnado's brand, for example, the views of the internal audience - employees, volunteers and other internal stakeholders - were seen as essential (Grounds and Harkness 1998).

This focus upon the internal conceptualisation of the brand is perhaps further understood when the complex nature of the management of internal stakeholder groups within non-profit organisations, together with their disparate communications needs, is taken into account. It is not surprising, therefore, that communications managers in non-profit organisations have relied heavily upon the development of a very simple, easily understood brand conceptualisation that has focused more upon the tangible and concrete aspects of the brand (logo, design features, corporate identity) than on their more intangible, values based, counterparts.

BRAND MANAGEMENT

Given the types of values that have been found in this research to predominate in non-profit organisations, a consultative and participative approach to brand management is crucial to the development of a coherent and powerful brand shared and recognised uniformly throughout the organisation. This position finds support in both the embryonic non-profit branding literature (Bruce 1998; Handy 1990), and in the growing recognition within the for-profit branding literature that if brands are to attain true authenticity, an alignment between the values of the organisation and those of the brand must be achieved (de Chernatony et.al. 1998).

To achieve the desired synergy between organisation and brand values the for-profit literature suggests that brands need to be tightly controlled with systems and processes that are pro-actively enforced by brand managers Keller (1998). By contrast, in the non-profit context our research findings suggest that the adoption of this enforcement approach to brand management sits uneasily with the necessity to adopt a consultative and participative approach. Indeed, given the particular nature of the values found present and deemed important to non-profit brands by respondents in this research, brand enforcement is likely to challenge the very values such as empowerment considered to be of such importance to many of the executives interviewed.

This is reflected in the more relaxed and flexible approach adopted to brand management in non-profit organisations as observed in our research findings. Whilst this approach may sit more comfortably with those values that underpin the behaviour of those organisations represented in the research, such a participative approach to brand management will result in a coherent and consistent brand identity only if considerable effort is made to ensure the key brand values truly encapsulate those values that the charity's stakeholder groups also consider to be of fundamental importance to both themselves and the work of the organisation.

Analysis of the research findings in the context of the for-profit branding literature would suggest therefore that there maybe significant differences between the conceptualisation and implementation of branding in the charity and commercial environments.

The Role Played by Values in the Branding Process

This research supports the claims made in the literature review that values lie at the heart of every non-profit organisation and should become the ‘bedrock’ of their work. It confirms the significance of values in the construction of the non-profit brand and in part at least, is in accord with the need for those values to be shared across the organisation (Bruce (1998). The concept of shared values amongst staff, said to be of such fundamental importance in studies on organisational culture (Deal and Kennedy 1982; Schein 1985), was referred to by a number of participants. One senior director commenting, *“I think the vast majority of people here really, really believe [this charity’s] work.”*

At a superficial level, the strength of the values construct within the non-profit brand context identified in this research should fit well with an ability to create highly effective intangible brand dimensions, capable of offering considerable emotional and self-expressive benefits to a wide range of stakeholders. However, to the contrary, at the current time, the majority of non-profit brand managers participating in this research seem reluctant to conceptualise their brand from a values based perspective. Where the minority did so, the values based element of the brand appears to be neither well defined across differing stakeholder groups, nor is it pro-actively promoted in a consistent manner as an integral component of brand development and management.

The challenge for non-profit brand managers, it would appear, is first to attain the identification and then the effective management of those values that drive organisational behaviour and provide meaning to both internal and external stakeholders.

Once achieved, identification of a clear set of core underlying values, would enable non-profits to create a clearer set of propositions in all of their branding communications that would cut across the multiple messages many of them currently appear to be communicating. In turn, enhanced clarity in the values proposition advanced as a core component within non-profit brands would help to facilitate a shift from the current introspective, internal focus on brand management to one that considers the needs of existing and indeed potential external stakeholder groups.

It seems likely therefore, given the highly distinctive nature of the constraints impacting on brand management in the non-profit sector, that brand managers in these organisations will need to look to new and equally distinctive remedies if non-profit branding is to mirror the development of commercial branding experience, progressing from management of the tangible aspects of the brand (logo, corporate identity) to the effective management of intangible values.

Whilst the adoption of proactive brand management would appear crucial to success if consistency in brand meaning, development and implementation are to be secured; in practice, to be truly effective at the brand values dimension, the nature and the style of the brand management employed in the non-profit context will be likely to be highly distinctive to that which currently characterises commercial experience.

If this is deemed an appropriate aspiration amongst non-profit brand managers, it is equally likely that the most effective remedies developed will not simply be the ‘hand me downs’ of past commercial experience, rather, they will emerge from a greater appreciation of what branding really means and can realistically deliver within non-profit organisations.

Limitations and Future Research

While this research has produced some interesting findings it is important to remember that it is an initial exploratory piece.

In developing this research it would be beneficial to broaden the sample base to include different groups of stakeholders. It will also be important to investigate in greater detail the implementation of the branding process in a larger number of charities. The findings from this and from subsequent qualitative studies could also provide the basis for a quantitative study to investigate the relationship between organisational values, donor values and donor commitment.

This paper has provided insights into the conceptualisation of branding in the non-profit environment. It has also considered brand implementation from the perspective of values based organisations and reviewed these findings within the context of for-profit branding literature. Finally it has raised the question whether the gap between the conceptualisation of branding in the two arenas is so great that the constructs are the same only in name and that in fact two different constructs are being wrongly compared

REFERENCES

- Aaker, D. A. (1996), *Building Strong Brands*, New York: Free Press.
- Aiken, M. (2001), "Keeping Close to Your Values: Lessons from a Study Examining How Voluntary and Co-operative Organisations Reproduce their Organisational Values", [online], Milton Keynes: Open University.
Available at: <http://technology.open.ac.uk/cru/publicatold.htm>, [Accessed 8th May 2006].
- Batsleer, J., Cornforth, C., et al. (1991), *Issues in Voluntary and Non-profit Management*, Wokingham: Addison Wesley.
- Becker, B. W. and Conner, P. E. (1986), "On the Status and Promise of Values Research", *Management Bibliographies and Reviews*, Vol. 12, No. 2, pp. 3-17.
- Belk, R. W. (1988), "Possessions and the Extended Self", *Journal of Consumer Research*, Vol.15, No.2, pp. 139 - 168.
- Berthon, B., Hulbert, J. M., et al. (1999), "Brand Management Prognostications", *Sloan Management Review*, Vol.40 , No.2 , pp. 53 - 65.
- Boulding, K. E. (1956), *The Image*, Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press.
- Bruce, I. (1998), *Successful Charity Marketing*, Hemel Hempstead: ICSA Publishing Limited.
- Cowls, D.L. Viecker, P. and Little M.W. (2002), "Using Key Informant Insights as a Foundation for E-retailing Theory Development", *Journal of Business Research*, Vol. 58, No. 8, pp. 629-636.
- de Chernatony, L. and F. Dall'Olmio Riley (1998), "Defining A "Brand": Beyond the Literature With Experts' Interpretations", *Journal of Marketing Management*, Vol.14, No.4/5, pp. 417-443.
- de Chernatony, L. (1999), "Brand Management Through Narrowing the Gap Between Brand Identity and Brand Reputation," *Journal of Marketing Management*, Vol. 15, No.3, pp. 157-179.
- Deal, T. E. and Kennedy A. A. (1982), *Corporate Cultures*, Harmondsworth: Penguin Books.
- Denscombe, M. (2003), *The Good Research Guide*, Philadelphia: Open University Press.
- Dey, I. (1993), *Qualitative Data Analysis*, London: Routledge.
- Drucker, P. (2001), *Managing the Non-Profit Organisation*, Oxford: Butterworth-Heinemann.
- George, J. and Reve, T. (1982), "The Reliability and Validity of Key Informant Data for Dyadic Relationships in Marketing Channels", *Journal of Marketing Research*, Vol.19, No.4, pp. 517-524.

- Grounds, J. and J. Harkness (1998), "Developing a Brand from Within: Involving Employees and Volunteers when Developing a New Brand Position", *Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing*, Vol. 3, No.2, pp. 179-184.
- Hammersley, M. and Atkinson P. (1995), *Ethnography, Principles in Practice*, London: Routledge.
- Handy, C. (1990), *Understanding Voluntary Organisations*, St Ives: Clays Ltd.
- Hankinson, P. (2000), "Brand Orientation in Charity Organisations: Qualitative Research into Key Charity Sectors", *International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing*, Vol. 5, No.3, pp. 207-219.
- Hudson, M. (1995), *Managing Without Profit*, London: Penguin.
- Ind, N. and Bell, M. (1999), "Freedom and Order: A Participative Approach to Corporate Branding", *Journal of Brand Management*, Vol. 7, No.1, pp. 19 -26.
- Kapferer, J.N. (1992), *Strategic Brand Management*, New York: Free Press.
- Keller, K. L. (1998), *Strategic Brand Management*, New Jersey: Prentice-Hall.
- Kotler, P. (1997), *Marketing Management*, New Jersey: Prentice-Hall.
- Low, G. S. and Fullerton, R.A. (1994), "Brands, Brand Management and the Brand Manager System: A Critical-Historical Evaluation", *Journal of Marketing Research* Vol.31, No.2 , pp. 173-190.
- Malhotra, N. K. (1988), "Self Concept and Product Choice, an Integrated Perspective", *Journal of Economic Psychology*, Vol. 9, No.1, pp. 1-28.
- Marshall, C. and Rossman G. B. (1999), *Designing Qualitative Research*, Thousand Oaks CA: Sage.
- Miles, M. B. and Huberman M. A. (1994), *Qualitative Data Analysis*, Thousand Oaks: CA, Sage.
- Naddaff, A. (2004), "Branding by Design", *Communication World*, Vol. 21, No. 5, pp. 18-19.
- Polonsky, M. J. and Macdonald, E. K. (2000), "Exploring the Link Between Cause-Related Marketing and Brand Building", *International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing*, Vol. 5, No.1, pp. 46-57.
- Quelch, J.A., Austin, J.E. and Laidler-Kylander, N. (2004), "Mining Gold in Not-for-Profit Brands", *Harvard Business Review*, Vol. 82, No. 4, pp. 24-25.
- Ritchie, R. J. B., Swami, S. et al. (1998), "A Brand New World for Nonprofits", *International Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing*, Vol. 4, No.1, pp. 26-42.
- Salamon, L. M. (1999), "The Nonprofit Sector at a Crossroads: The Case of America", *Voluntas: International Journal of Voluntary and Nonprofit Organisations*, Vol. 10, No.1, pp. 5 -23.
- Sargeant, A., Hudson, J. and Ford, J.B. (2005), "Charity Brand Personality: Distinguishing Sector, Cause and Organisation", *Proceedings 34th Annual ARNOVA Conference*, Washington DC: ARNOVA.
- Sargeant, A. and Lee, S. (2004), "Trust and Relationship Commitment in the United Kingdom Voluntary Sector: Determinants of Donor Behavior", *Psychology & Marketing*, Vol. 21, No.8, pp. 613-635.
- Schein, E. H. (1985), *Organizational Culture and Leadership*, San Francisco: Jossey-Bass Publishers.
- Sternberg, P. (1998), "The Third Way: The Repositioning of the Voluntary Sector", *Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing*, Vol.3, No.3, pp. 209-217.
- Stride, H. (2003), "An Investigation into the Values Dimensions of Branding: Implications for the Charity Sector", *Henley Management College: Henley Working Paper Series*, No.0319, pp.1-28.
- Tapp, A. (1996), "Charity Brands: A Qualitative Study of Current Practice", *Journal of Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Marketing*, Vol. 1, No.4, pp. 327-336.
- Wray, R., B (1994), "Branding Development and Positioning the Charity." *Journal of Brand Management*, Vol. 1, No.6, pp. 363-370.

APPENDIX 1 SEMI-STRUCTURED INTERVIEW GUIDE

- 1 What terminology do you use when talking about the organisation's image or identity?
- 2 What are the component parts of your brand?
- 3 In developing your brand what were your key objectives?
- 4 How do you manage the process of communicating your brand to a wide range of audiences?
- 5 What will be the key challenges in achieving the above?
- 6 Who manages your brand?
- 7 What are the values of your organisation?
- 8 How are they arrived at?
- 9 How do you operationalise the organisation's brand values?
- 10 Are there systems and mechanisms in place to ensure that the organisation's values are reflected in how people deal with enquiries?
- 11 What do you think needs to be in place in order to develop and maintain a strong brand?
- 12 What are the consequences to an organisation of developing a brand?

ABOUT THE AUTHOR AND CORRESPONDENCE

Helen Stride is a Research Associate of the Centre for Voluntary Sector Management at Henley Management College and a Development Fellow in the School of Reputation and Relationships. In addition to working on research projects in the Centre, she has co-authored the College's Branding E Elective on which she tutors; co-ordinates Personal Development on the Advanced Management Programme and works as a Learning and Development Advisor across a range of College taught programmes. She is an NLP Practitioner and Henley Accredited Executive Coach.

Corresponding Author: Helen Stride, Research Associate, Centre for Voluntary Sector Management, Henley Management College, Greenlands, Henley-on-Thames, Oxon RG9 3AU, UK.

T +44 1491 571 454

F +44 1491 571 635

Stephen Lee is Professor of Non-Profit and Public Sector Management Henley Management College where he is also Director of the Centre for Voluntary Sector Management. He is also currently visiting Professor of Marketing at the University of Geneva and previously a visiting Senior Research Fellow, South Bank University Business School. Principle current research interests include Public Trust and Confidence in Relationship Marketing; the application of marketing disciplines to non-profit and public sector markets; Branding and Reputation Management; Strategic planning within the Public, Private Sector Partnership context; Ethical, Governance and Data Protection issues.

Professor Stephen Lee, Director, Centre for Voluntary Sector Management, Henley Management College, Greenlands, Henley-on-Thames, Oxon RG9 3AU, UK

T +44 1491 571 454

F +44 1491 571 635